



The climate crisis

The negative impact of human activity on Earth's climate was first brought to wide public attention in the 1970s. Yet over the following decades, governments were slow to react to the issue. Today, young people around the world, angry at this inaction, are demanding environmental reforms.

▲ POLLUTION

When harmful materials, called pollutants, are added to the environment, they can damage the quality of our air, water, and land, which humans and animals depend on for survival. Burning fuel for electricity, and smoke from factories and cars, releases carbon dioxide and pollutes the air; sewage can make people ill and damage sea life; and chemicals used in farming can flow into the land.

FACT

Sea ice reflects the sun's heat back up into space like a mirror. As Arctic ice melts, the ocean absorbs more sunlight and heats up, which scientists believe may result in ice-free summers by 2030.

Since the Industrial Revolution in the 18th century, human progress has been powered by the burning of fossil fuels such as coal, oil, and gas. As we switched to producing goods by machine in factories, we started to burn more fossil fuels for energy.

Burning these fuels releases carbon dioxide into the air, which traps the sun's heat, not letting it escape Earth's atmosphere. This is similar to how the glass of a greenhouse works,

and is known as the "Greenhouse Effect." As carbon dioxide levels rise, temperatures rise, too, leading to warmer oceans, melting polar ice, and rising sea levels.

Young activists are impatient with slow government action to reduce carbon emissions. They are pressuring for more action, and are also doing what they can to reduce their own carbon footprint—the amount of carbon dioxide they release.



▲ GLOBAL WARMING

The Greenhouse Effect causes temperatures around the world to rise in a phenomenon called global warming. This term was first used by US geoscientist Wallace Broecker, who brought worldwide attention to global warming in 1975. Higher temperatures make natural disasters such as forest fires more common.

▼ PLASTIC

The first plastics were only developed at the beginning of the 20th century, but in a relatively short time they have caused massive environmental problems. Plastic waste can take hundreds of years to break down, and chemicals in plastic can also pollute water. But many plastics can be reused and recycled into new materials.

